



Final Year Project:

Department of Electrical and Electronics Engineering

GSM Signal Denoising and Modulation Classification for Rural Uganda

Improving Connectivity in Underserved Areas Using Machine Learning

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Background

33.2 million Ugandans

exchanged

421.5 million GBs

in 2022

UCC reports that network subscriptions reached **33.2 million** by the end of 2022, and mobile data traffic doubled from 217 million GB in 2020 to 421.5 million GB in 2022 showing an exponential growth in network service demand. [1]

31% of Ugandans

have 5G

62% of Ugandans

Lack mobile internet access

Unfortunately, network expansion is failing to keep pace with this demand; only 31% of the population and 24% of the landmass have 4G coverage and 62% of the population (30 million people) still lacks mobile internet access, and live in low SNR, high-interference environments where the signal is weak (below -90 dBm), the noise becomes louder than the message, making it impossible for standard tools to understand what is being sent[3][4][5][6]

Most Ugandans still use basic phones

Many people in rural Uganda still use basic phones for calls and Mobile Money, but the signal is often very weak and are being blocked or "noised up" by illegal boosters, unlicensed community radios (Bizindaalo), and heavy tropical rain.

[7][23][24][25]

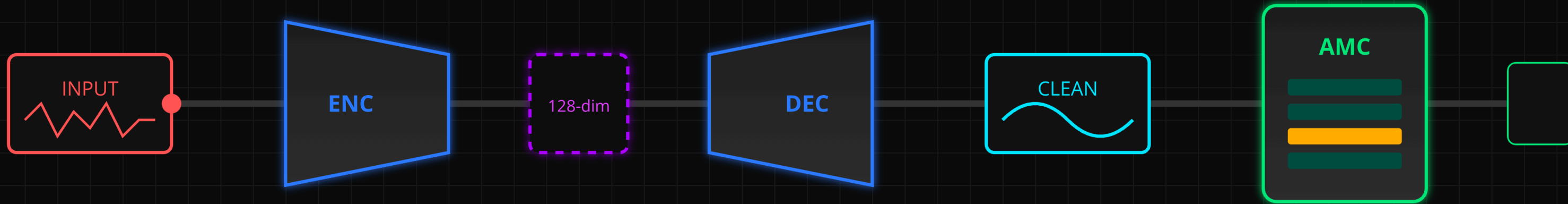
Background continuation

- **Automatic Modulation Classification (AMC)** is crucial for regulators to monitor the spectrum, manage interference, and identify illegal broadcasters that threaten critical services like aviation. [7]
- We propose using a **Denoising Autoencoder (DAE)** combined with an **Automatic Modulation Classifier (AMC)** system that takes a noisy signal (e.g., at -90 dBm or even lower) and actively cleans it up removing noise before trying to classify or demodulate it. [5][8][15][26]
- Instead of just trying to read a noisy signal, our system first cleans the signal to make it clear again making sure that even in the most remote sub-counties, the network can still identify and process signals correctly. [8][15][26]



Problem Statement

- Many people in rural Uganda still use basic phones for calls and Mobile Money, but the signal is often very weak. In weak signal environments below -90 dBm, the noise is always louder than the message signals, making it impossible for standard tools to decode understand what is being transmitted [5][6]
- On top of that, signals are sometimes blocked or noised up by illegal boosters, unlicensed community radios (Bizindaalo), and heavy tropical rain. [7][23][24][25]
- The Uganda Communications Commission (UCC) finds it hard to catch illegal broadcasters because current tools and technology cannot see through all this noise. [7][23] This leads to dropped calls, failed Mobile Money transactions, and poor service for over 30 million Ugandans and over 70% of call failures in some areas. [3][6] [27]
- We lack smart ways of Identifying and cleaning noise in signals before processing them.



Main Objective

Design a Hybrid DAE-AMC Pipeline

To design, implement, and empirically evaluate a hybrid **Denoising Autoencoder–Automatic Modulation Classification (DAE-AMC) pipeline** that suppresses interference in noisy I/Q streams and maintains accurate modulation decisions across low SNR channel conditions observed in Ugandan networks.

Specific Objectives

01 Design

Define the hybrid DAE-AMC architecture, select the working datasets, and model Uganda-specific low-SNR interference conditions such as booster oscillation, Bizindaalo harmonics, and rain fade

02 Implementation

Develop and train the Conv1D denoising autoencoder, implement the AMC classifier for GSM-family modulations, and integrate both blocks into a single signal-processing pipeline.

03 Analysis

Evaluate the hybrid DAE-AMC pipeline against a standalone AMC baseline using accuracy, F1-score, confusion matrices, and SNR-wise performance trends.

Justification and Significance

Meeting UCC Mandates:

The DAE is explicitly trained on SNR conditions matching UCUSAF's ``-90 dBm`` coverage floor, addressing the "near-far" interference documented by UCC QoS audits rather than a generic low-SNR scenario. [5][23][27]

It Aligns with National Policy:

Our project supports Uganda's national development plans (NDPIII/NBP) that call for more spectrum-efficient technologies. It replaces older, brittle handcrafted methods with a robust, cost-effective, software-based AI algorithm for enhancing signals by removing noise. [4][15][26]

Spectrum Surveillance

It will help with the detection of illegal transmitters and interference mitigation for aviation and public-safety channels. [7][23]

Rural Broadband

It will help maintain reliable service in low-SNR environments, supporting **30 million Ugandans** lacking mobile internet access. [3][6]

Critical Services

It supports stability for Mobile Money and e-government services that depend on reliable radio links. [5][6]

Scope



Offline Experimentation

Project conducted entirely on a computer using pre-existing data, ensuring a controlled environment.



Datasets

DeepSig RadioML 2018.01A benchmark data provides synthetic, well-characterized SNR labels, while the RF Signal Data collection on Kaggle provides real SDR captures that introduce hardware impairment realism. [11][12]



Noise Modelling

We inject Uganda-specific noise profiles such as Booster oscillation noise as High-power wideband impulses simulating illegal repeater feedback, Bizindaalo harmonics as Narrowband tones at 2nd/3rd harmonics of FM frequencies (200 MHz, 300 MHz sidebands leaking into 900 MHz), Rain fade attenuation as Time-varying SNR reduction modeling tropical storm conditions (100+ mm/h rainfall rates)



Model Development

Focus on a Conv1D Denoising Autoencoder (DAE) and a supervised AMC classifier.



Specific Modulations

Training models to recognize GSM-family modulations like GMSK, GFSK, and QPSK



Platform & Tools

Python, PyTorch, Jupyter Notebook, and supporting visualization or cloud tools where needed.



Timeline

A 6-month dedicated period for research, model development, and comprehensive testing.

Literature Review

Chapter Two



Classical Methods

Early Automatic Modulation Classification (AMC) relied on statistical analysis and manually engineered features. While elegant, these methods are brittle and fail completely in the low-signal, high-interference environments common in Uganda.



Key Limitation:

- They are not robust under unknown channels
- These impairments are documented by UCC in congested Ugandan deployments and motivate the transition toward data-driven feature learning. [7][23][27]

Machine learning as the new standard

Modern research has shifted to deep learning models such as CNNs, Transformers, and Mixture-of-Experts frameworks. These models can learn features directly from raw signal data and have shown significant accuracy improvements, especially in low-SNR conditions down to -10 dB. [15][16][26]

GSM Noise Mitigation in African Networks

While DAE-based signal enhancement has been extensively studied academically, its application to African GSM networks' specific interference environment remains unexplored. [8][26]

Regulatory Interventions

UCC's zero-tolerance posture has led to enforcement operations that confiscate illegal boosters and shut down unlicensed Bizindaalo stations. Proliferation continues, however, due to porous borders and sustained demand. [7][23]

Technical Countermeasures

Modern 4G/5G systems use Massive MIMO and beamforming, but these are unavailable for legacy 2G/GSM deployments in rural areas. NBI fiber expansion helps reduce microwave backhaul reliance. [4][24]

The Research Gap

No published work applies ML-based denoising to UCC-documented GSM interference, including booster oscillation, Bizindaalo harmonics, and tropical rain fade.

[7][8][23][24][25][26]

We fill that gap by training a DAE on synthetic noise profiles matching documented interference vectors, enabling GMSK classification at SNR levels where conventional approaches fail. [8][15][26]

Machine Learning in AMC

Deep learning has reshaped AMC by learning discriminative features directly from raw I/Q samples. Recent contributions demonstrate tangible low-SNR gains:

AbdElaziz et al. (2023)

1

CNN with parallel asymmetric kernels achieved 96.5% accuracy at 0 dB and 86.1% at -2 dB across nine modulations. [15]

2

Zhang et al. (2023)

MoE-AMC mixture-of-experts framework yielded ~71.8% averaged accuracy across -20...18 dB. [16]

Meta-Transformer (2024)

3

Leverages transformer encoders and few-shot learning to adapt rapidly to unseen modulations while maintaining superior accuracy. [30]

4

Rehman et al. (2025)

DL AMC converts I/Q streams into eye diagrams, overcoming the 10–48% accuracy ceiling near -10 dB SNR.

Denoising Autoencoders for Signal Enhancement

Denoising frontends have emerged as an effective countermeasure when raw I/Q features are overwhelmed by interference.

75%

Classification accuracy across $-12\ldots 8$ dB .

Dual residual DAE with channel attention improved AMC accuracy by up to 75% across $-12\ldots 8$ dB SNR. [8]

77.5%

accuracy at -10 dB

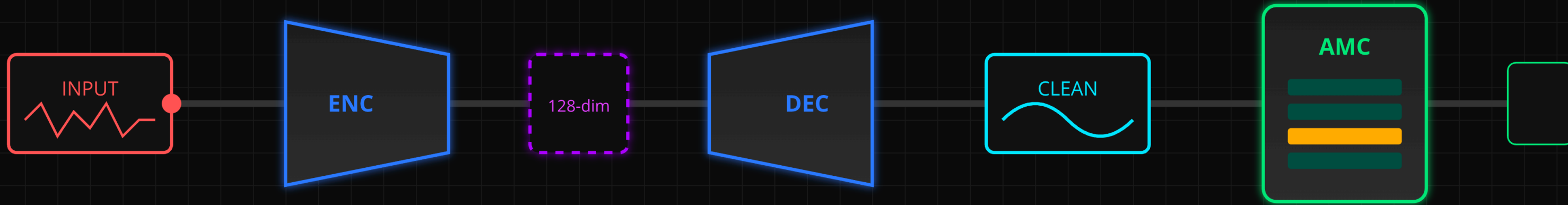
Faysal et al.'s multimodal denoising masked autoencoder sustained `77.5%` accuracy at ` $-10$  dB`, roughly `22%` higher than the non-denoised case. [28]

70%

relative accuracy gains on low-SNR samples.

An and Lee's thresholded autoencoder with an SNR predictor delivered about `70%` relative accuracy gains on low-SNR samples. [29]

These findings justify the DAE-AMC architecture explored in this project and provide design cues for gating strategies that conserve energy on SDR deployments. [8][26][28][29]



CHAPTER THREE – METHODOLOGY

A comprehensive framework for developing robust Automatic Modulation Classification systems tailored to challenging RF environments through deep learning and denoising techniques.

Introduction to Methods

We adopt an experimental research design anchored in reproducible data processing and quantitative benchmarking which is why our methodology is organized into three linked parts: **design**, **implementation**, and **analysis**. [11][12][15][16][26]

01 DESIGN

This stage defines the full architecture and experiment setup before training begins.

-  - Select the datasets to be used, primarily RF Signal Data and RadioML 2018.01A. [11][12]
-  - Harmonize all signals into a unified tensor format with `1024`-sample windows and normalized amplitude.
-  - Perform exploratory data analysis (EDA) to inspect class balance, SNR coverage, waveform quality, and impairment patterns before training. [11][12]
-  - Define the GSM-focused modulation classes: GMSK, GFSK, and QPSK.
-  - Model Uganda-specific interference using booster oscillation, Bizindaalo harmonics, and rain-fade attenuation. [7][23][24][25]
-  - Specify the system architecture showing how the denoising block feeds the modulation classifier.

Expected outcome: A complete project design package comprising the architecture diagram, dataset specification, low-SNR scenario definitions, and the experimental setup for the DAE-AMC pipeline.

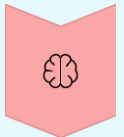
Methodology

02 IMPLEMENTATION

This stage converts the design into working models and an integrated signal-processing pipeline.



- Train a Conv1D encoder-decoder DAE on noisy and clean I/Q pairs using MSE-based reconstruction loss. [8][26][28]



- Train a supervised AMC classifier on GSM-family modulations using both raw and denoised inputs. [15][16]



- Integrate the DAE and AMC blocks into a hybrid pipeline and compare frozen and fine-tuned configurations. [8][26][28][29]

- Build a lightweight prototype interface for visualizing noisy signals, denoised outputs, and classification predictions.

Expected outcome: A functional hybrid DAE-AMC prototype capable of denoising noisy I/Q samples and producing modulation predictions under controlled low-SNR conditions.

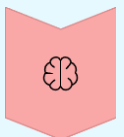
Methodology

03 ANALYSIS AND EVALUATION

This stage measures whether the proposed pipeline improves modulation recognition under the targeted interference conditions.



- Benchmark the hybrid DAE-AMC system against a standalone AMC baseline. [15][16]



- Evaluate denoising quality and classification quality across held-out SNR ranges. [8][26][28][29]



- Use accuracy curves, macro F1-score, confusion matrices, and SNR-wise comparisons to quantify improvement. [15][16][26]
- Interpret the results in terms of rural Uganda use cases such as weak-signal monitoring, interference diagnosis, and regulator demonstrations.

Expected outcome: A clear evidence set showing where the hybrid pipeline improves over baseline AMC, including result plots, comparative metrics, and conclusions about suitability for rural Uganda spectrum-monitoring scenarios.

Project Budget Overview

The successful execution of this project requires a structured allocation of resources. The total estimated budget is **1,750,000 UGX**, covering critical areas from software to research.

Item	Cost (UGX)
Software Licenses	300,000
Data Curation	100,000
Nvidia GPUs	500,000
Cloud Databases	100,000
Internet and Research	200,000
Printing and Documentation	50,000
Miscellaneous	500,000
Total Estimated Cost	1,750,000

This budget ensures that all necessary technical infrastructure, data processing capabilities, and operational requirements are adequately funded to support the project's objectives.

Project Timeline

Our project will be executed in five distinct phases, ensuring a structured and efficient progression towards our objectives over a 27-week period.

Phase	MONTH 1				MONTH 2				MONTH 3				MONTH 4				MONTH 5				MONTH 6			
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
Problem Framing and Literature Review																								
Data Acquisition, EDA, and Preprocessing																								
Model Design and Architecture																								
Implementation and testing																								
Evaluation and Analysis																								
Documentation and Submission																								

This timeline ensures a methodical approach to each stage, culminating in a robust and well-documented solution for intelligent signal processing.

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Thanx for Listening